

Coping frameworks for OCD/health anxiety patients during medical waiting periods — Action Checklist

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KNOW YOUR SPIRAL SIGNATURE

- ☐ **Know Your Spiral Signature:** Notice your unique physical warning signs that appear before catastrophic thoughts begin, including heart rate elevation, chest tightness, and tingling sensations during the waiting period.
- ☐ **Know Your Spiral Signature:** Identify the compulsive urge to check symptoms, verify information, or search online as a signal that OCD logic is taking over your rational thinking during medical waits.
- ☐ **Know Your Spiral Signature:** Observe moments when all you can focus on is the potential threat and your attention narrows completely, which indicates your spiral cascade is beginning to lock in.
- ☐ **Know Your Spiral Signature:** Track your consistent spiral patterns by remembering that the cascade starts with your body, not your thoughts, so monitoring physical sensations gives you an earlier intervention window.

DEPLOY THE INTERRUPT SEQUENCE

- ☐ **Deploy the Interrupt Sequence:** Press your palms together firmly and push against each other for 10 seconds to activate proprioceptive receptors and signal safety to your hijacked nervous system during spirals.
- ☐ **Deploy the Interrupt Sequence:** Name three specific objects you can see in your environment by color and type, such as the blue pen and white light switch, to force your prefrontal cortex to engage and interrupt the amygdala hijack.
- ☐ **Deploy the Interrupt Sequence:** Hold something cold or press your palms against a cool surface for 15 seconds to trigger one of the fastest physiological brakes available for anxiety activation during spirals.
- ☐ **Deploy the Interrupt Sequence:** Say out loud or in your head, This is the wait. The result has not arrived, as a factual reality anchor that grounds you in present reality without attempting to provide reassurance.

BREAK THE PHYSICAL LOOP

- ☐ **Break the Physical Loop:** Stand up and walk to a different room immediately when you notice your spiral signature beginning, using physical relocation to interrupt the freeze response that accompanies cascades.
 - ☐ **Break the Physical Loop:** Shift your posture from sitting to standing or standing to walking, using any movement to break the physical loop before the spiral fully takes hold of your body and mind.
 - ☐ **Break the Physical Loop:** Resist the urge to perform safety behaviors like excessive checking, online searching, or reassurance-seeking, because these compulsions signal danger to your nervous system and amplify the spiral.
 - ☐ **Break the Physical Loop:** Move your body in any small way, even standing up and sitting back down, because motion disrupts the loop at the body level where spirals actually originate rather than at the thought level.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.